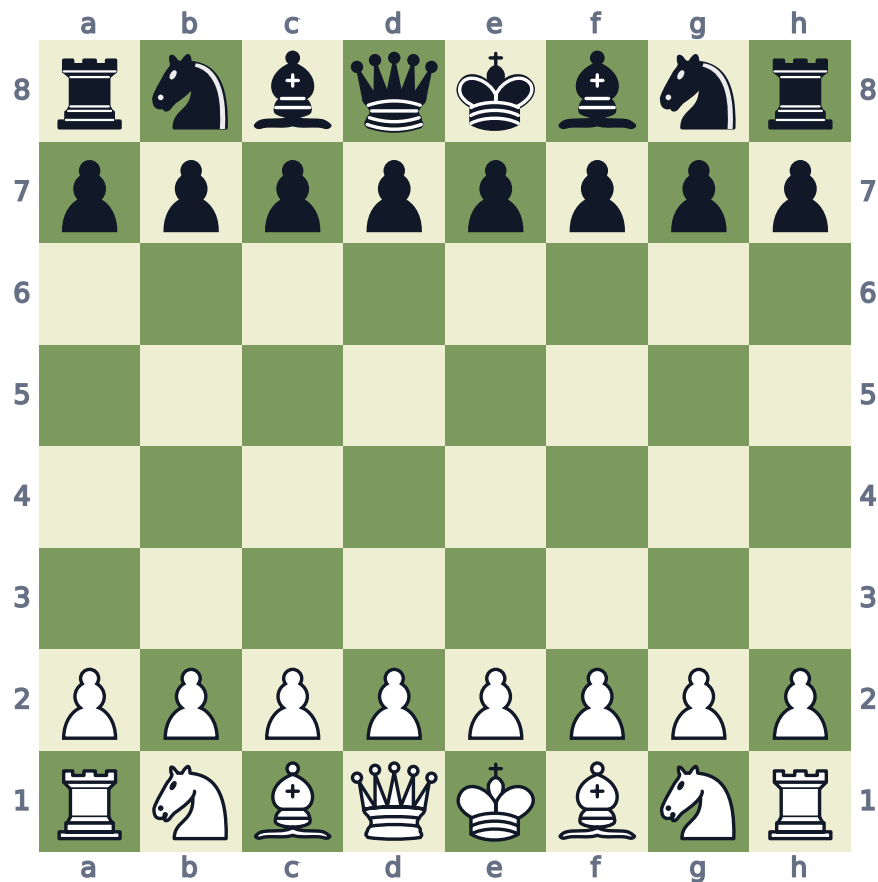


Defensive Chess and Prophylaxis

Threat recognition, active resistance, and counterplay



Defend without panic by naming the threat, reducing the attacker's options, returning material when necessary, and creating active counterplay.

23 learning units | explanations | board laboratories | review system

ORIENTATION

What this course will change

COURSE PROMISE

Defend without panic by naming the threat, reducing the attacker's options, returning material when necessary, and creating active counterplay.

YOU WILL LEARN TO

- Distinguish real threats from visual pressure
- Choose active or passive defense correctly
- Use exchanges, blocks, flight squares, and counterattacks
- Recognize fortresses and perpetual-check resources

HOW TO USE THE COURSE

- Study one learning unit at a time. Say the rule in your own words before continuing.
- At each diagram, hide the model answer. Write candidates and the opponent's best reply.
- Use the rule during a slow game, then record whether it actually changed a decision.
- Review after 1, 3, 7, 14, and 30 days. Retrieval matters more than rereading.

SCOPE

This course contains 23 integrated learning units. Principles guide attention, but tactics and exact calculation always decide the move.

CORE METHOD

The decision protocol

USE THIS EVERY TIME

A reliable process is more valuable than a brilliant idea used occasionally. Practice the sequence until it becomes automatic under clock pressure.

1**Name the threat precisely.****2****Search for active defense before passive repair.****3****Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.****4****Calculate the attacker's best continuation.****5****Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.****STOPPING RULE**

Choose when one candidate is sufficiently verified for the clock situation. Before moving, inspect the position once from the opponent's perspective.

COURSE MAP

Learning units

- 01 Identify the Real Threat
- 02 Meet a Wing Attack in the Center
- 03 Trade Attacking Pieces
- 04 Return Material to Neutralize the Initiative
- 05 Create a Flight Square
- 06 Defend Actively With Counter-Threats
- 07 Avoid Weakening a Color Complex
- 08 Simplify Pressure Into a Defensible Ending
- 09 Ask What the Opponent Wants
- 10 Overprotect a Critical Square
- 11 Challenge the Base of a Fianchetto
- 12 Exchange Sacrifices Need Positional Returns
- 13 Use an Open Rook-Pawn File Against the King
- 14 Control Flight Squares Before Checking
- 15 Bring the Worst Attacker Into the Attack
- 16 Offer a Queen Trade to Break the Attack
- 17 Blockade the Pawn Storm
- 18 Counter-Sacrifice to Remove the Initiative
- 19 Perpetual Check Is an Active Defensive Resource
- 20 Defend the Entry Square, Not Every Attacked Pawn

COURSE MAP

Learning units

- 21 Use Stalemate as an Active Defense
- 22 Construct a Perpetual-Check Zone
- 23 Remove the Opponent's Tactic First

LEARNING UNIT 01

Identify the Real Threat

THE RULE

Name the opponent's concrete threat and its required conditions before choosing a defense.

WHY IT WORKS

Fear produces passive moves against imaginary dangers. Precise threat identification reveals whether to prevent, ignore, counter, or exploit the idea.

RECOGNITION CUES

Opponent moves near your king; sacrifice seems possible; several defensive moves tempt you.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Some threats are positional rather than tactical. Include pawn breaks, exchanges, and improved piece placement.

BOARD LABORATORY 01

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nfd7 5. f4 c5 6. Nf3 Nc6 7. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Identify the Real Threat'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Fear produces passive moves against imaginary dangers. Precise threat identification reveals whether to prevent, ignore, counter, or exploit the idea. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten defensive positions, write the threat as a legal move sequence, not a vague phrase.

LEARNING UNIT 02

Meet a Wing Attack in the Center

THE RULE

Seek central counterplay when the opponent has committed time and pawns to one flank.

WHY IT WORKS

Central opening activates more pieces at once and may expose the attacker's king or unsupported center.

RECOGNITION CUES

Pawn storm; unstable central pawns; your pieces can support a break.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

If the center is locked or your break is tactically unsound, direct defense may be necessary.

BOARD LABORATORY 02

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... c6 2. d4 d5 3. e5 Bf5 4. Nf3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Meet a Wing Attack in the Center'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Central opening activates more pieces at once and may expose the attacker's king or unsupported center. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For five attacking positions, calculate the defender's central break before considering pawn-shell moves.

LEARNING UNIT 03

Trade Attacking Pieces

THE RULE

Exchange the enemy units most responsible for threats, especially queens or key minor pieces.

WHY IT WORKS

An attack depends on coordination. Removing one participant can reduce mating threats below the required force.

RECOGNITION CUES

Opponent has several pieces near your king; a favorable trade is available; endgame is defensible.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not trade a harmless piece while leaving the decisive attacker. Avoid exchanges that ruin your structure without reducing danger.

BOARD LABORATORY 03

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Trade Attacking Pieces'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: An attack depends on coordination. Removing one participant can reduce mating threats below the required force. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For ten defensive positions, rank the opponent's attackers by importance and seek a trade for number one.

LEARNING UNIT 04

Return Material to Neutralize the Initiative

THE RULE

Give back extra material when it completes development, trades attackers, or removes king danger.

WHY IT WORKS

Holding every pawn can force passivity and allow the initiative to grow. Returning part of the gain can convert a dangerous position into a stable one.

RECOGNITION CUES

You are materially ahead but undeveloped; king is exposed; opponent has strong piece activity.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not surrender material automatically. Calculate whether accurate defense preserves both safety and the extra material.

BOARD LABORATORY 04

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Return Material to Neutralize the Initiative'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Holding every pawn can force passivity and allow the initiative to grow. Returning part of the gain can convert a dangerous position into a stable one. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Study ten accepted gambits and mark the best moment to return material, if any.

LEARNING UNIT 05

Create a Flight Square

THE RULE

Give the king an escape square when back-rank or mating-net danger is concrete.

WHY IT WORKS

A single legal retreat can remove entire tactical themes and free rooks from passive defense.

RECOGNITION CUES

King boxed by pawns; enemy rook or queen controls entry line; back-rank tactics are possible.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Pawn moves around the king create holes and cost time. Create luft only when its value exceeds those costs.

BOARD LABORATORY 05

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3... cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nf6 5. Nc3 g6 6. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Create a Flight Square'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A single legal retreat can remove entire tactical themes and free rooks from passive defense. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

In ten castled positions, classify luft as urgent, useful, unnecessary, or weakening.

LEARNING UNIT 06

Defend Actively With Counter-Threats

THE RULE

Prefer defensive moves that improve pieces, attack the opponent, or create escape options.

WHY IT WORKS

Purely passive defense lets the attacker add pieces indefinitely. Counter-threats consume the attacker's time and can force simplification.

RECOGNITION CUES

Several defensive moves work; one can attack queen, king, or central base; your pieces are passive.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

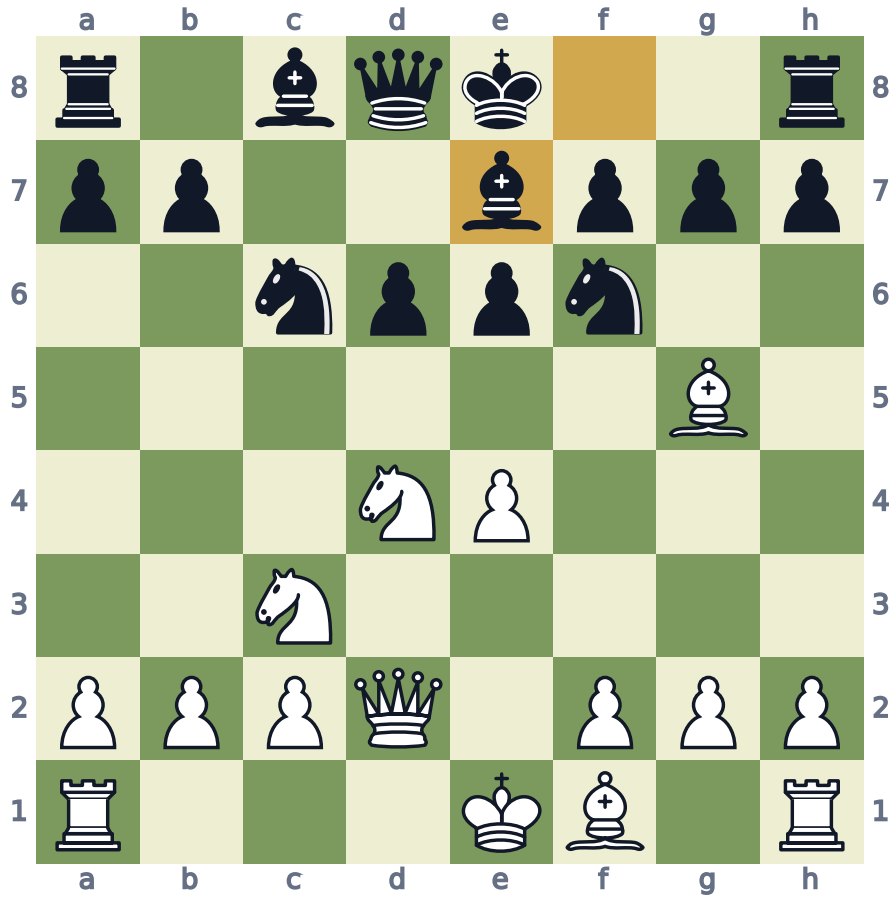
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- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A counter-threat fails if the opponent's attack is faster or forcing. Calculate move order precisely.

BOARD LABORATORY 06

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5. Nc3 Nc6 6. Bg5 e6 7. Qd2 Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Defend Actively With Counter-Threats'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Purely passive defense lets the attacker add pieces indefinitely. Counter-threats consume the attacker's time and can force simplification. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For ten threats, find one passive defense and one active defense, then compare the opponent's reply freedom.

LEARNING UNIT 07

Avoid Weakening a Color Complex

THE RULE

Do not move or exchange the pawns and pieces controlling one color around your king without checking enemy access.

WHY IT WORKS

When same-colored squares lose pawn control and their defending bishop, enemy pieces can occupy them permanently.

RECOGNITION CUES

Fianchetto bishop may be exchanged; king pawns move onto one color; enemy queen and bishop form a battery.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

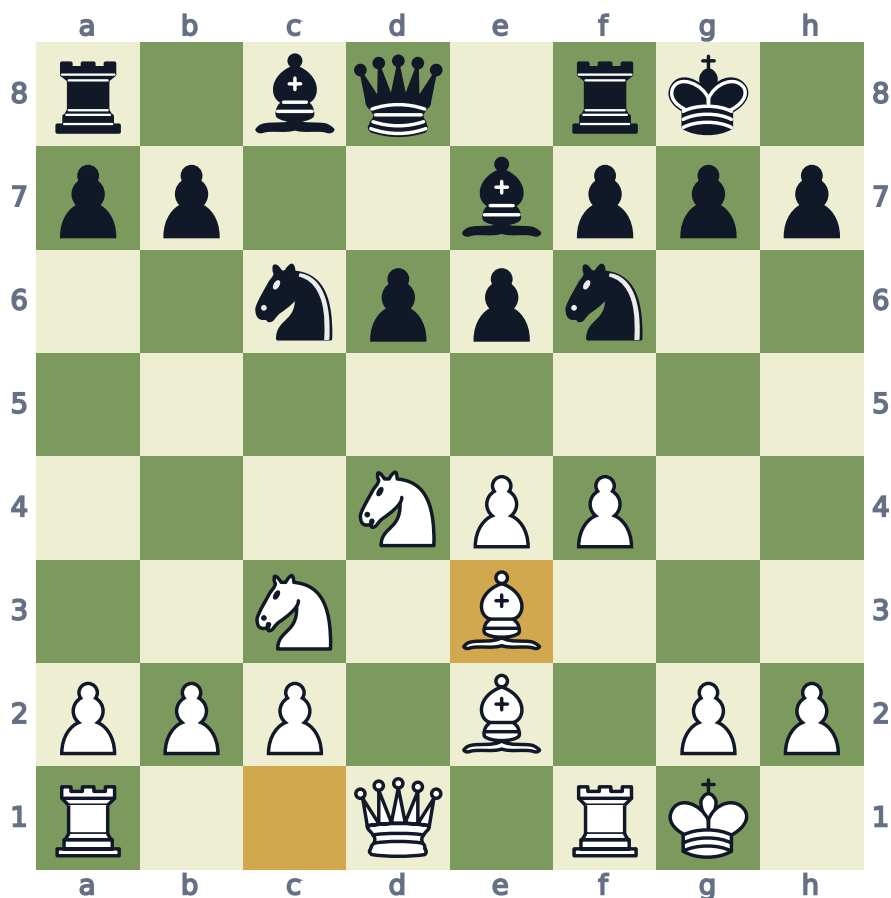
- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A weakened color complex matters only if the opponent has a route and pieces capable of exploiting it.

BOARD LABORATORY 07

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



6... Be7 7. O-O O-O 8. f4 Nc6 9. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Avoid Weakening a Color Complex'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: When same-colored squares lose pawn control and their defending bishop, enemy pieces can occupy them permanently. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For ten king positions, color the weak squares and identify the enemy piece most able to invade.

LEARNING UNIT 08

Simplify Pressure Into a Defensible Ending

THE RULE

Offer exchanges when the resulting endgame removes attack and remains structurally viable.

WHY IT WORKS

Fewer queens and attacking pieces reduce tactical danger. A clear endgame can be easier to hold than a materially equal but exposed middlegame.

RECOGNITION CUES

Under sustained attack; queen trade available; endgame material and pawn structure can be evaluated.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

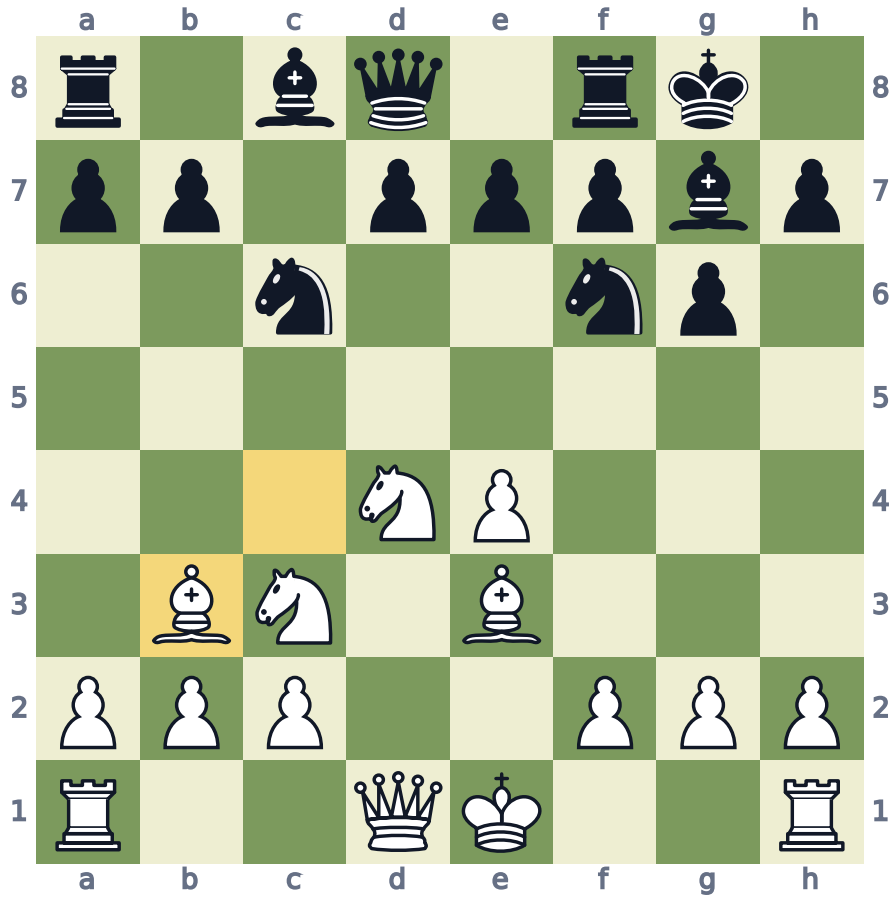
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- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not simplify into a technically lost pawn ending or a passive rook ending without counterplay.

BOARD LABORATORY 08

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5... Bg7 6. Be3 Nf6 7. Bc4 O-O 8. Bb3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Simplify Pressure Into a Defensible Ending'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Fewer queens and attacking pieces reduce tactical danger. A clear endgame can be easier to hold than a materially equal but exposed middlegame. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

For ten queen-trade opportunities, evaluate the resulting ending before deciding whether simplification helps.

LEARNING UNIT 09

Ask What the Opponent Wants

THE RULE

Before executing your own plan, identify the opponent's best improvement and consider preventing it cheaply.

WHY IT WORKS

Prophylaxis reduces the opponent's strongest options while preserving your plan. It is efficient control of future possibilities.

RECOGNITION CUES

Quiet position; opponent has a clear break or piece route; one useful move can hinder it.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

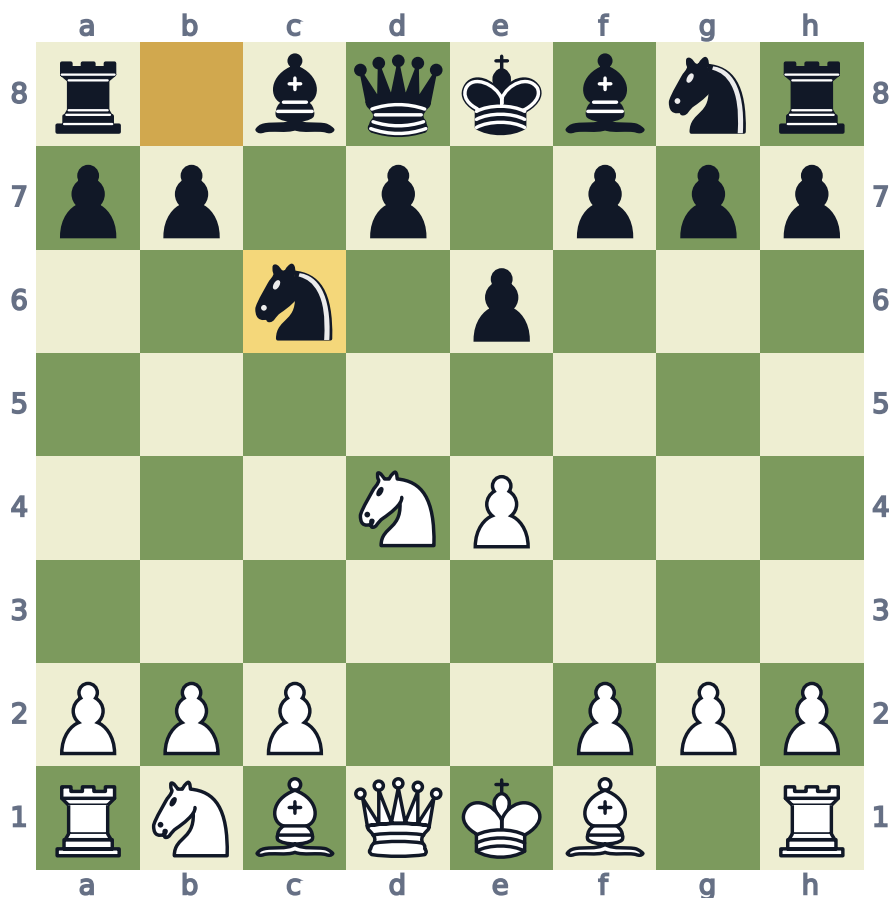
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- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Do not spend tempi stopping harmless plans. Prevention should be cheaper than the danger prevented.

BOARD LABORATORY 09

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



2. Nf3 e6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4 Nc6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Ask What the Opponent Wants'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Prophylaxis reduces the opponent's strongest options while preserving your plan. It is efficient control of future possibilities. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

At ten master-game positions, predict the opponent's plan and choose one move that hinders it without weakening your side.

LEARNING UNIT 10

Overprotect a Critical Square

THE RULE

Defend a strategically important square with more pieces than immediately necessary when it anchors your position or future activity.

WHY IT WORKS

Extra defenders gain flexibility: one can leave for another task without collapsing the position. The square also becomes a coordination hub.

RECOGNITION CUES

Central outpost; key pawn break square; one square supports several plans.

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

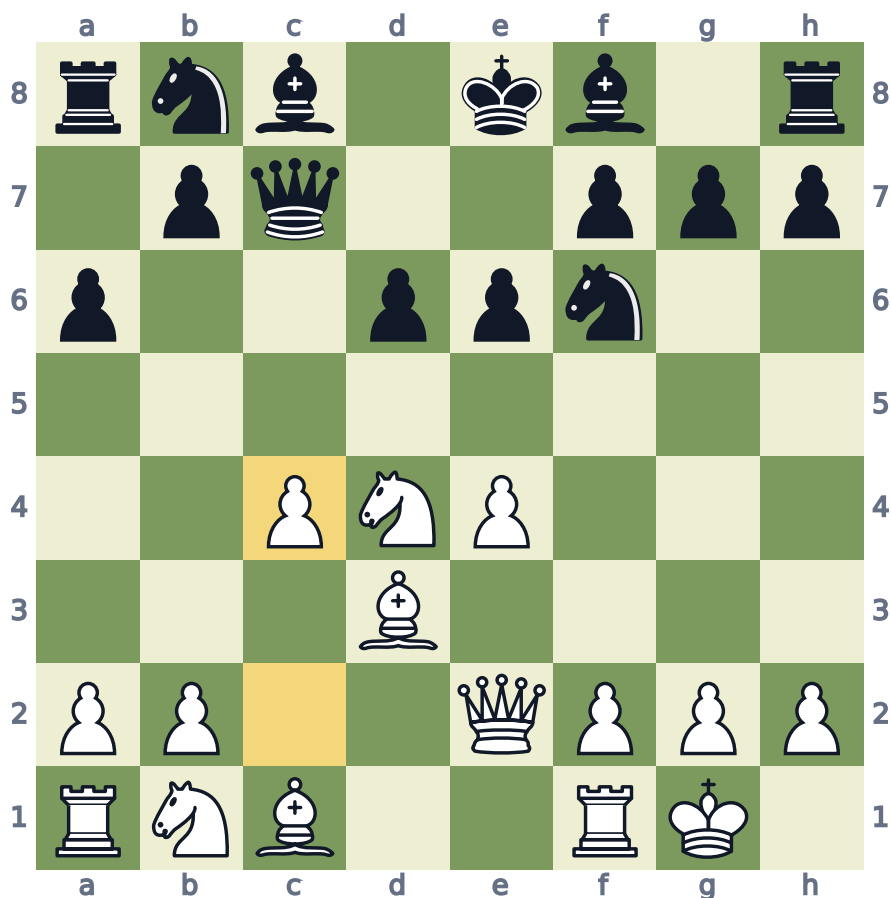
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- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Overprotection is wasteful when the square has no practical role or pieces become passive merely to defend it.

BOARD LABORATORY 10

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5... Qc7 6. O-O Nf6 7. Qe2 d6 8. c4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Overprotect a Critical Square'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Extra defenders gain flexibility: one can leave for another task without collapsing the position. The square also becomes a coordination hub. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Choose five critical squares and show how each defender also performs a second useful job.

LEARNING UNIT 11

Challenge the Base of a Fianchetto

THE RULE

Attack the pawn and bishop complex supporting a fianchettoed king rather than sacrificing automatically on the shelter.

WHY IT WORKS

The fianchetto bishop guards key color squares. Exchanging it or undermining its pawns can create lasting entry squares for queen and minor pieces.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

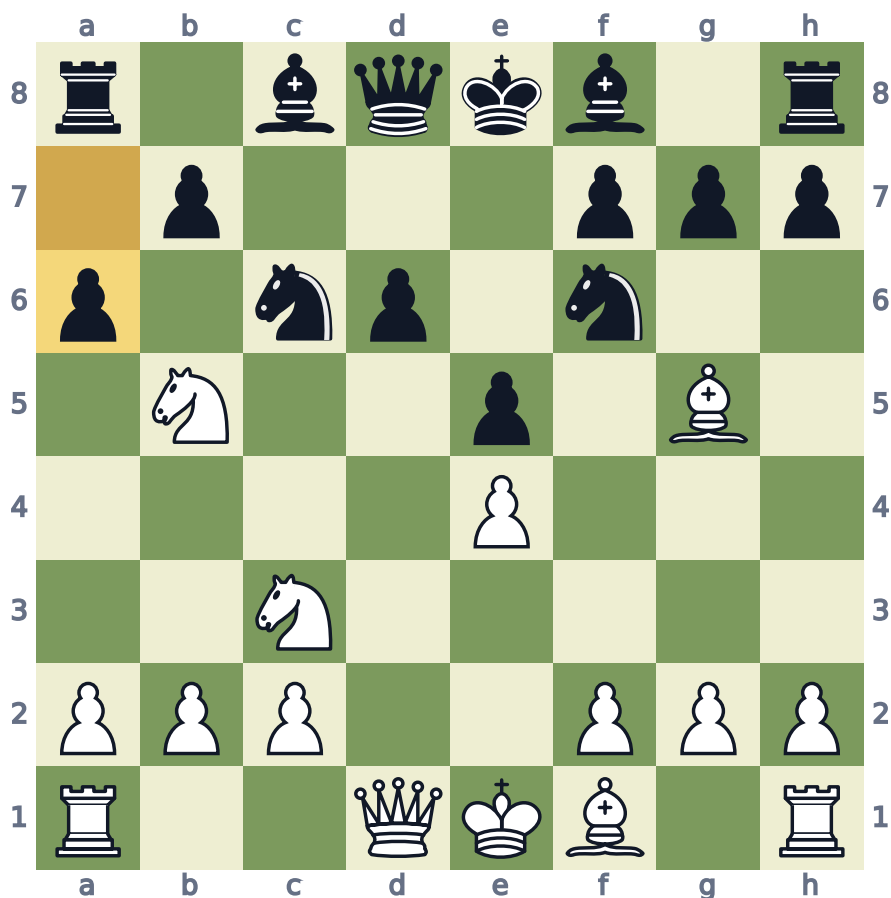
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- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 11

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



5. Nc3 e5 6. Ndb5 d6 7. Bg5 a6

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Challenge the Base of a Fianchetto'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: The fianchetto bishop guards key color squares. Exchanging it or undermining its pawns can create lasting entry squares for queen and minor pieces. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving challenge the base of a fianchetto. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 12

Exchange Sacrifices Need Positional Returns

THE RULE

Give a rook for a minor piece only when the resulting squares, pawns, king exposure, or domination provide durable compensation.

WHY IT WORKS

The nominal two-point loss can be offset by removing a crucial defender, destroying structure, or establishing pieces the opponent cannot challenge.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

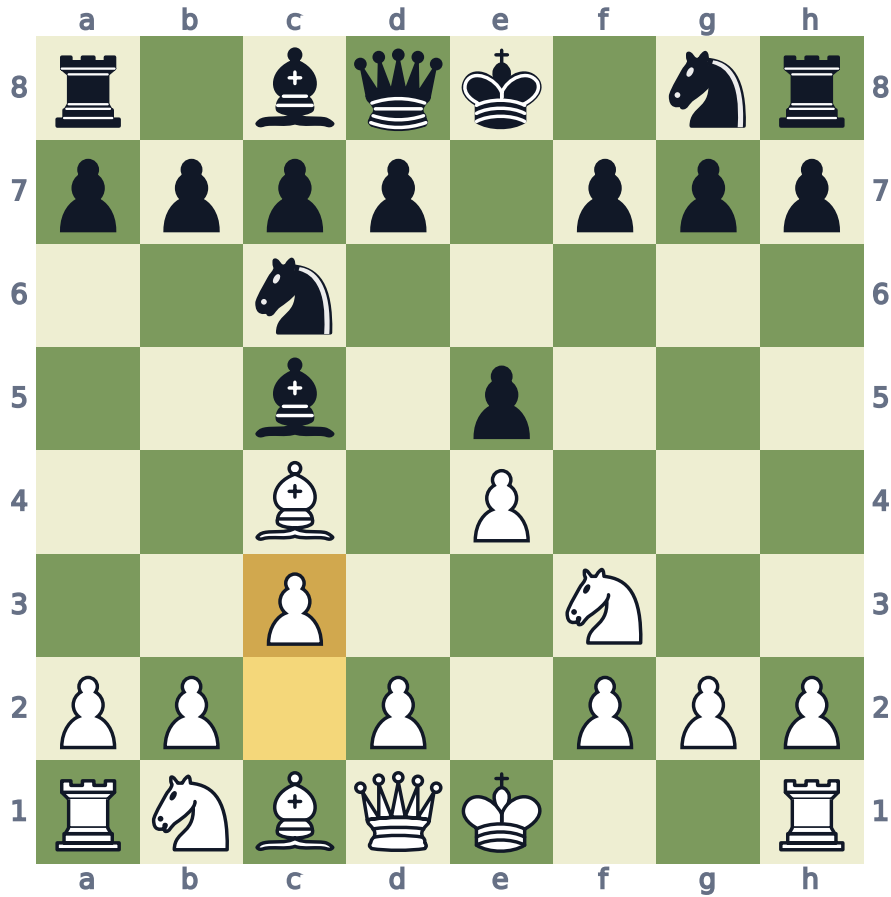
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BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 12

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Exchange Sacrifices Need Positional Returns'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: The nominal two-point loss can be offset by removing a crucial defender, destroying structure, or establishing pieces the opponent cannot challenge. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving exchange sacrifices need positional returns. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 13

Use an Open Rook-Pawn File Against the King

THE RULE

Place a rook or queen on an opened h- or a-file when it leads directly to the castled king.

WHY IT WORKS

Pawn exchanges can create a straight attacking highway. Control of the entry square and the defender's rook-pawn geometry determine whether it is decisive.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

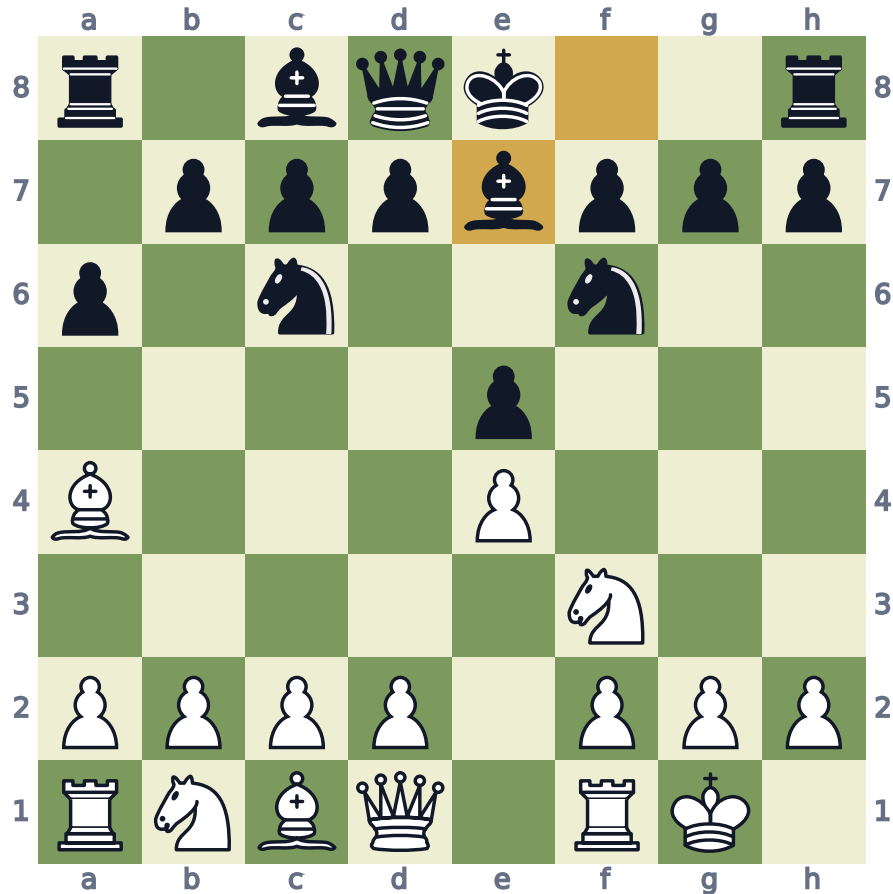
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- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 13

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. Bb5 a6 4. Ba4 Nf6 5. O-O Be7

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use an Open Rook-Pawn File Against the King'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Pawn exchanges can create a straight attacking highway. Control of the entry square and the defender's rook-pawn geometry determine whether it is decisive. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving use an open rook-pawn file against the king. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 14

Control Flight Squares Before Checking

THE RULE

Build a mating net by restricting the king's destinations before spending checks.

WHY IT WORKS

Checks without containment may help the king escape. Controlled flight squares convert ordinary checks into forcing progress and reduce defensive branches.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

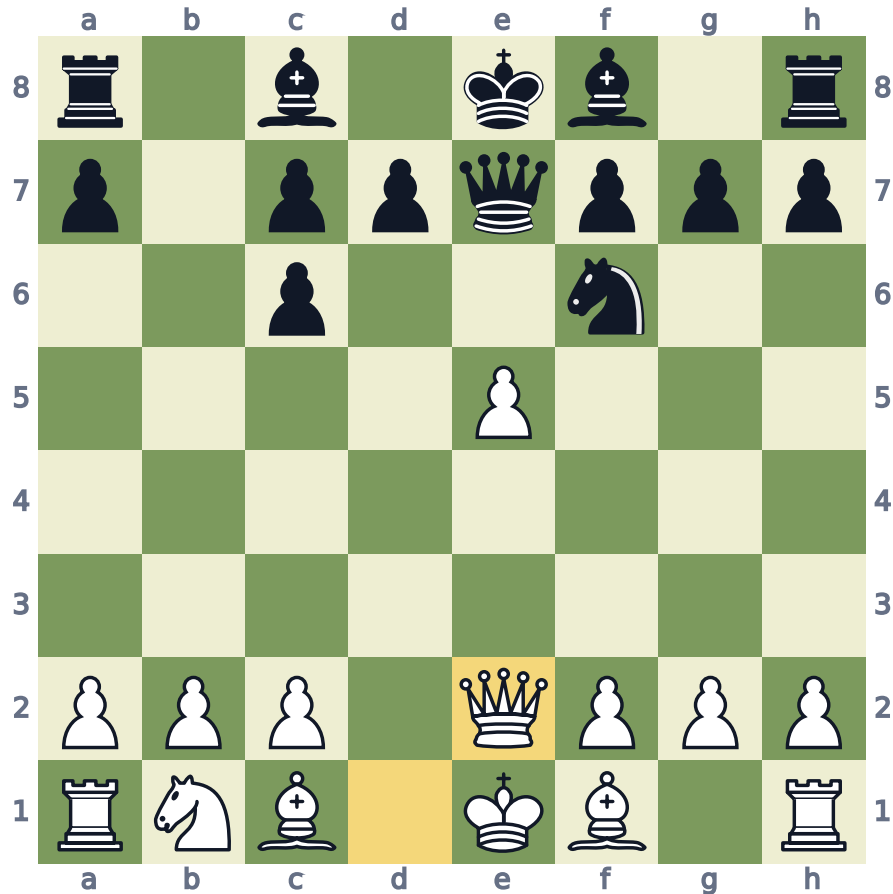
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- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 14

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nf6 5. Nxc6 bxc6 6. e5 Qe7 7. Qe2

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Control Flight Squares Before Checking'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Checks without containment may help the king escape. Controlled flight squares convert ordinary checks into forcing progress and reduce defensive branches. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving control flight squares before checking. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 15

Bring the Worst Attacker Into the Attack

THE RULE

Before forcing matters, improve the attacking piece contributing least.

WHY IT WORKS

An attack often stalls because one rook, bishop, or knight remains outside the king zone. Adding it increases threat density and reduces defensive freedom.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

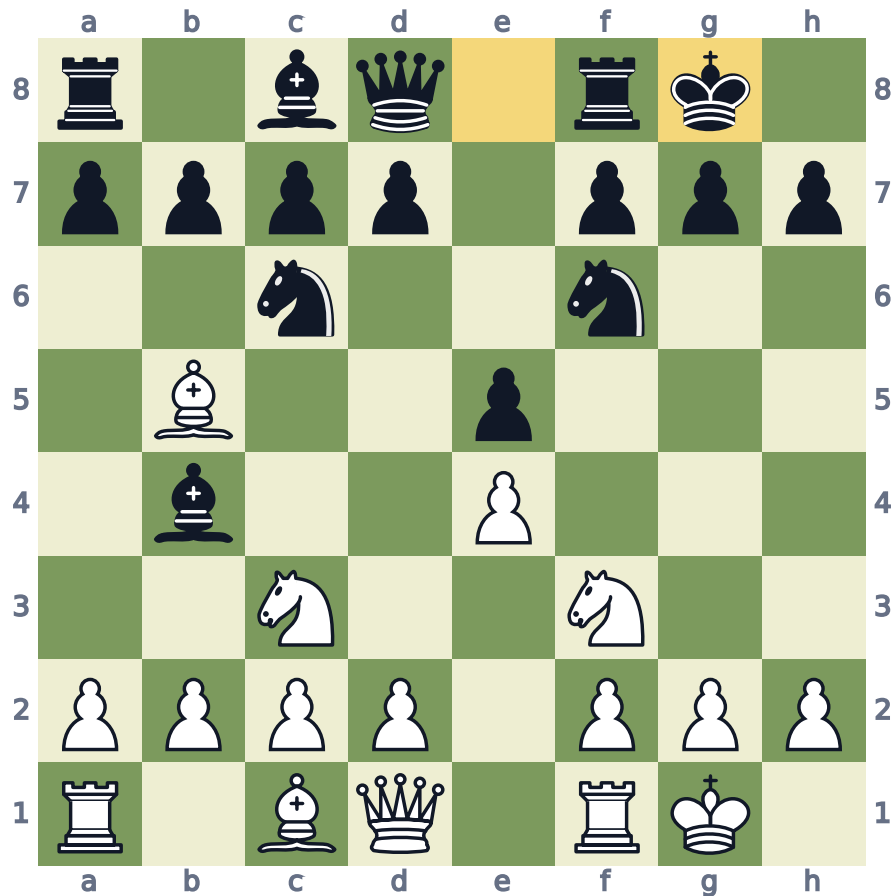
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- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 15

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bb5 Bb4 5. O-O O-O

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Bring the Worst Attacker Into the Attack'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: An attack often stalls because one rook, bishop, or knight remains outside the king zone. Adding it increases threat density and reduces defensive freedom. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving bring the worst attacker into the attack. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 16

Offer a Queen Trade to Break the Attack

THE RULE

When defending, use a queen exchange threat to force the attacker to lose time or abandon key squares.

WHY IT WORKS

Most mating attacks require queens. Even a declined exchange can displace the attacking queen and interrupt coordination.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

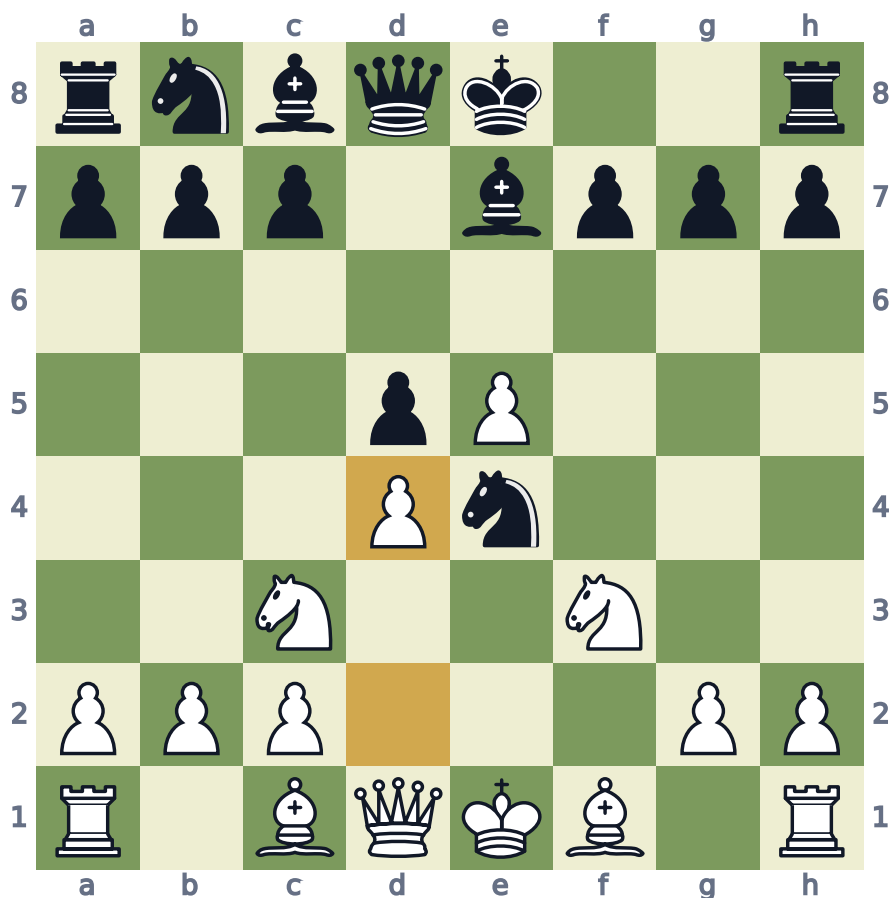
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- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 16

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3... d5 4. fxe5 Nxe4 5. Nf3 Be7 6. d4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Offer a Queen Trade to Break the Attack'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Most mating attacks require queens. Even a declined exchange can displace the attacking queen and interrupt coordination. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving offer a queen trade to break the attack. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 17

Blockade the Pawn Storm

THE RULE

Stop attacking pawns on fixed squares before they can open files against your king.

WHY IT WORKS

A blocked pawn can become a shield for the defender and a target for pieces. Restraint buys time for central or opposite-wing counterplay.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

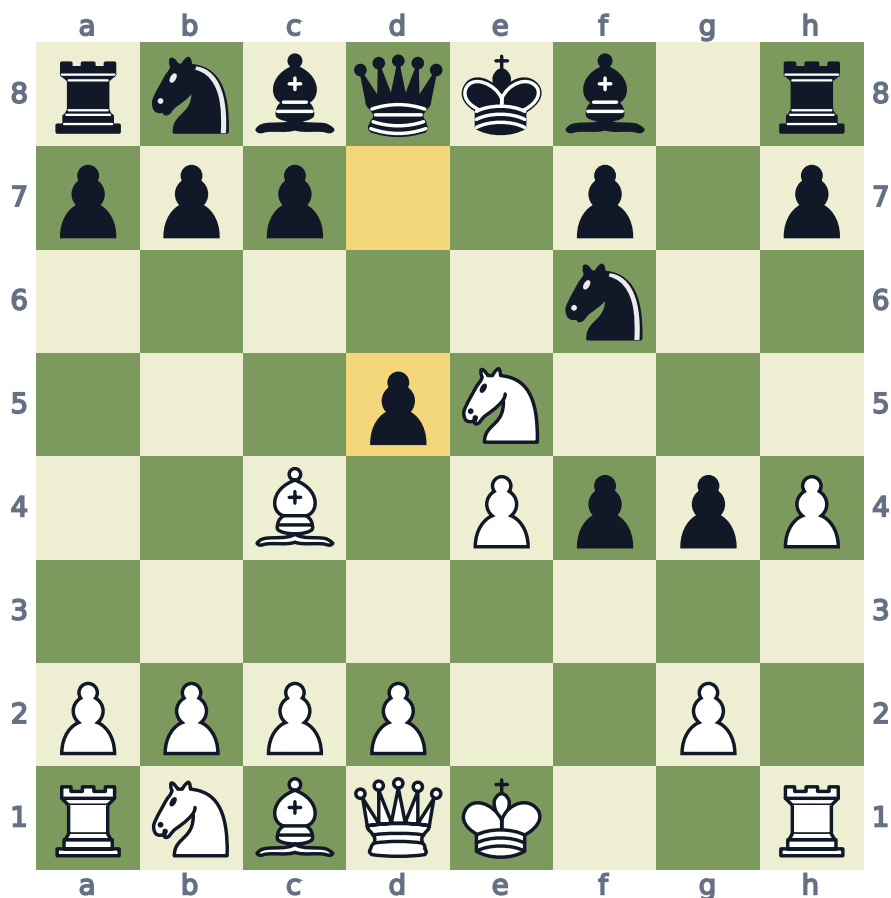
- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 17

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4. h4 g4 5. Ne5 Nf6 6. Bc4 d5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Blockade the Pawn Storm'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A blocked pawn can become a shield for the defender and a target for pieces. Restraint buys time for central or opposite-wing counterplay. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving blockade the pawn storm. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 18

Counter-Sacrifice to Remove the Initiative

THE RULE

Return or invest material to open escape squares, trade attackers, or seize forcing counterplay.

WHY IT WORKS

A counter-sacrifice changes the move-order obligation. The attacker may be forced to defend or enter a simplified position where the original initiative disappears.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 18

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



6... Bd6 7. O-O O-O 8. c4 c6 9. Nc3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Counter-Sacrifice to Remove the Initiative'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A counter-sacrifice changes the move-order obligation. The attacker may be forced to defend or enter a simplified position where the original initiative disappears. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving counter-sacrifice to remove the initiative. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 19

Perpetual Check Is an Active Defensive Resource

THE RULE

Search for repeated checking geometry when material defense is impossible.

WHY IT WORKS

A vulnerable opposing king can compensate for material loss. Repetition prevents conversion and forces the stronger side to address king safety.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

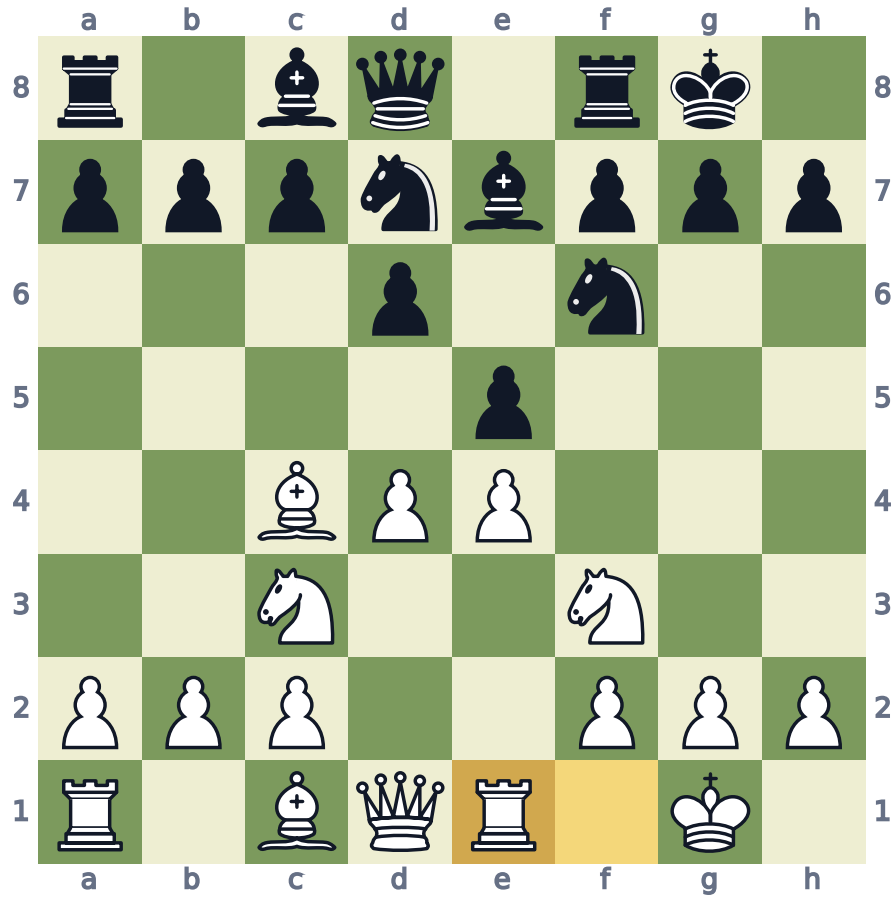
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- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 19

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... Nbd7 5. Bc4 Be7 6. O-O O-O 7. Re1

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Perpetual Check Is an Active Defensive Resource'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A vulnerable opposing king can compensate for material loss. Repetition prevents conversion and forces the stronger side to address king safety. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving perpetual check is an active defensive resource. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 20

Defend the Entry Square, Not Every Attacked Pawn

THE RULE

Prioritize the invasion point that would make the opponent's pressure decisive.

WHY IT WORKS

Many pawn attacks are tolerable until a rook or queen penetrates. Controlling the entry square can make several apparent threats harmless.

RECOGNITION CUES

One king has reduced shelter; several pieces can enter the king zone; attack and counterplay are developing at different speeds

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

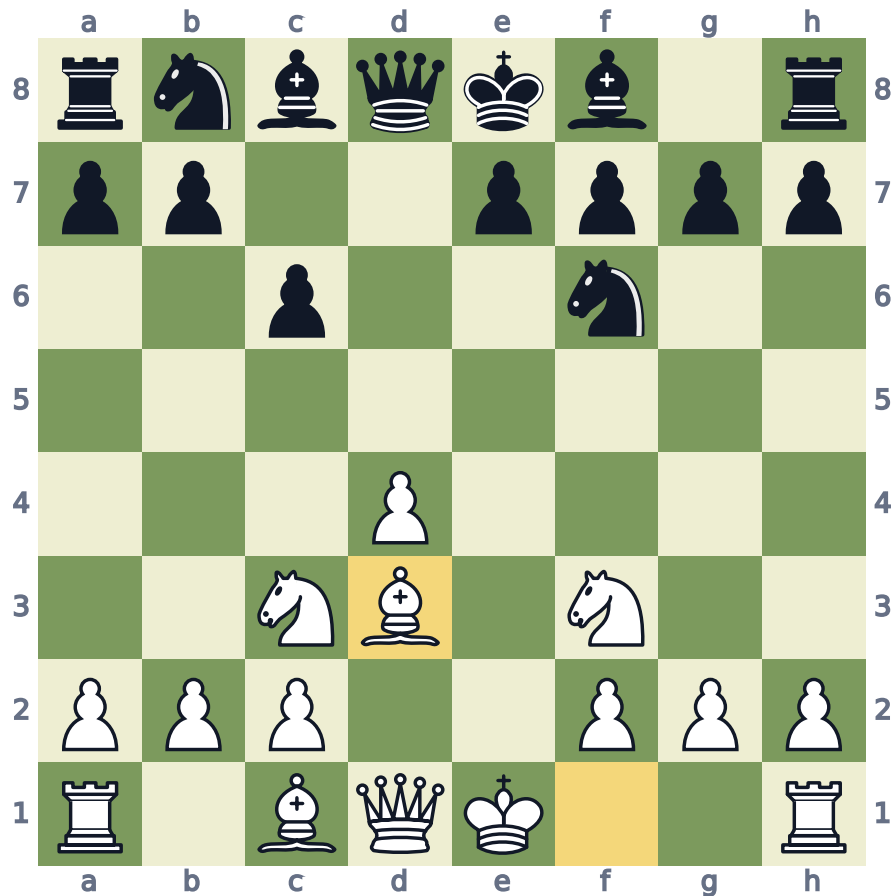
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- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

King attacks are concrete. Count effective attackers, defenders, forcing replies, and escape squares instead of trusting visual excitement.

BOARD LABORATORY 20

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3... Qd8 4. d4 Nf6 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bd3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Defend the Entry Square, Not Every Attacked Pawn'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Many pawn attacks are tolerable until a rook or queen penetrates. Controlling the entry square can make several apparent threats harmless. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Analyze ten attacking or defensive positions involving defend the entry square, not every attacked pawn. Write the attacker's fastest line and the defender's most active resource.

LEARNING UNIT 21

Use Stalemate as an Active Defense

THE RULE

When material is lost, search for ways to remove every legal move from your own king and pieces.

WHY IT WORKS

Stalemate changes the objective from saving material to eliminating mobility. Sacrificing remaining pieces or fixing one's own pawns can force a draw even when normal defense has collapsed.

RECOGNITION CUES

a king has limited squares; one piece performs two defensive jobs; a line could open with tempo; a forcing move changes the geometry

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A familiar motif is only a search cue. Confirm the legal move order, the opponent's best defense, and the final material and king-safety balance before committing.

BOARD LABORATORY 21

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



3. Nc3 Nf6 4. e5 Nfd7 5. f4 c5

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Use Stalemate as an Active Defense'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Stalemate changes the objective from saving material to eliminating mobility. Sacrificing remaining pieces or fixing one's own pawns can force a draw even when normal defense has collapsed. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Use Stalemate as an Active Defense'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven...

LEARNING UNIT 22

Construct a Perpetual-Check Zone

THE RULE

Identify a set of checking squares the king cannot escape without allowing another check.

WHY IT WORKS

A perpetual is a geometric loop. The defender draws when the king's shelter and the attacker's checking routes repeat faster than the winning side can interpose, trade queens, or reach safety.

RECOGNITION CUES

a king has limited squares; one piece performs two defensive jobs; a line could open with tempo; a forcing move changes the geometry

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

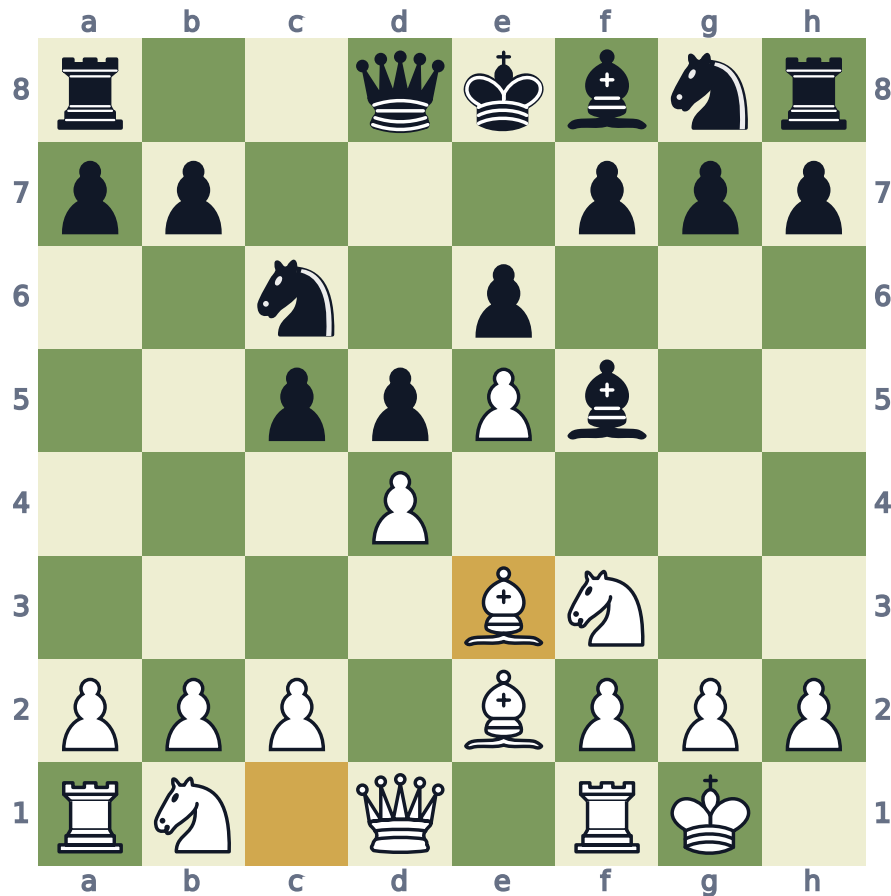
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-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A familiar motif is only a search cue. Confirm the legal move order, the opponent's best defense, and the final material and king-safety balance before committing.

BOARD LABORATORY 22

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



4... e6 5. Be2 c5 6. O-O Nc6 7. Be3

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Construct a Perpetual-Check Zone'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: A perpetual is a geometric loop. The defender draws when the king's shelter and the attacker's checking routes repeat faster than the winning side can interpose, trade queens, or reach safety. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Construct a Perpetual-Check Zone'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days; scor...

LEARNING UNIT 23

Remove the Opponent's Tactic First

THE RULE

Before launching your idea, ask which enemy tactical resource could invalidate it and neutralize that resource.

WHY IT WORKS

Tactical prophylaxis preserves freedom. A small move that unpins a piece, creates luft, or removes a countercheck can turn an unsound combination into a clean one by deleting the opponent's only forcing reply.

RECOGNITION CUES

a king has limited squares; one piece performs two defensive jobs; a line could open with tempo; a forcing move changes the geometry

APPLY IT OVER THE BOARD

- Name the threat precisely.
- Search for active defense before passive repair.
- Consider exchange, block, flight square, material return, and counterattack.
- Calculate the attacker's best continuation.
- Choose the defense that leaves the fewest future problems.
-

BOUNDARY CONDITION

A familiar motif is only a search cue. Confirm the legal move order, the opponent's best defense, and the final material and king-safety balance before committing.

BOARD LABORATORY 23

Use the idea, then try to disprove it



1... c5 2. Nf3 d6 3. d4 cxd4 4. Nxd4

YOUR TASK

Without moving the pieces, apply 'Remove the Opponent's Tactic First'. List two or three candidates, the opponent's strongest forcing reply, and the feature that makes the principle relevant or irrelevant here.

MODEL ANSWER STANDARD

A strong answer does more than name the rule. It explains the mechanism: Tactical prophylaxis preserves freedom. A small move that unpins a piece, creates luft, or removes a countercheck can turn an unsound combination into a clean one by deleting the opponent's only forcing reply. Then it verifies the best opposing reply and evaluates the resulting material, king safety, activity, structure, and initiative.

TRAINING TRANSFER

Collect twelve positions connected to 'Remove the Opponent's Tactic First'. For each, write three candidates, the opponent's strongest reply, and a one-sentence evaluation. Revisit the same positions without notes after three and seven days.

RETRIEVAL TEST

Can you explain the course without looking?

1

State the five-step decision protocol from memory.

2

Name three recognition cues that should make you slow down.

3

Choose five learning units and explain the causal mechanism behind each rule.

4

For each chosen rule, give one position where it should not be applied mechanically.

5

Describe the opponent's strongest practical resource in your most recent serious game.

6

Name one recurring error and the exact training drill that addresses its cause.

SCORING

2 points: accurate rule plus mechanism. 1 point: useful but incomplete. 0 points: slogan only. Restudy any item below 2 and retrieve it again tomorrow.

TRAINING PLAN

Four weeks to make the ideas usable

WEEK 1 - UNDERSTAND

Study the first quarter of the course. After every lesson, explain why the rule works and when it fails.

WEEK 2 - RECOGNIZE

Study the second quarter. Mix old and new diagrams so the name of the motif is not given in advance.

WEEK 3 - CALCULATE

Finish the course. Use a clock and write candidates, best defense, and endpoint evaluation.

WEEK 4 - TRANSFER

Play two slow games. Mark every moment when the course's protocol changed your decision, then analyze unaided.

LONG-TERM REVIEW

Return after 7, 14, and 30 days. Do not reread first. Attempt the retrieval test, review only missed items, and find one example from your own games.

REFERENCE

How this course fits the library

COURSE ROLE

Defend without panic by naming the threat, reducing the attacker's options, returning material when necessary, and creating active counterplay.

LIBRARY PRINCIPLE

Strong chess comes from a loop: notice the right features, generate serious candidates, calculate the opponent's best resistance, evaluate the destination position, and learn from the decision process.

ABOUT THE DIAGRAMS

Boards use Cburnett-style vector chess pieces with solid dark pieces and high-contrast olive and cream squares. Piece artwork is credited to Colin M. L. Burnett and the Lichess Cburnett set under GPLv2+.

EDITION NOTES

First edition, September 2026. 23 learning units. Explanations and exercises are designed for personal study and should be tested against actual games and concrete calculation.

THE FINAL QUESTION

What will you do differently on your very next move? If the course has not changed a behavior, choose one rule, attach it to a visible board cue, and practice it in five slow games.